

Master Plan Implementation Committee (MPIC) Solar Subcommittee Meeting
Minutes Thursday, November 7, 2024

Present: Teri Anderson, Susan Bronstein, Jen Milikowsky, Scott Stanton (taking minutes), Phil Dowling, Zachary from PowerOptions, Vito Perrone (School Superintendent), Andrea McGrath (Elementary School Principal)

Call to Order 5:30pm

Zach PowerOptions updates from the last time the committee met with him.

- PowerOptions now has a project navigator which can help us save \$ on EV chargers with incentives especially until 12/31/24 purchase.
- Power Purchase Agreement is too high at the moment to make it the best financial option for the town. SMART 3.0 will come out in January with new incentive numbers which will allow us to estimate the long best financial model for the project, but Ownership in the long run is most likely the better decision. Plan for a 30-40 year project life and anticipate long-term heating system upgrades. It is possible to change ownership model to a PPA throughout the process, sometimes into the beginning of construction of the project if that becomes the more financially desirable approach. The committee will also need assistance with the timeline for designing and constructing the project for writing the grant application early next year since we anticipated a two-year grant application. We need to determine the appropriate deliverables and costs for each year of the grant.

Committee Discussion on Proceeding with Project:

School committee and solar subcommittee both have some concerns about the canopy option and want more information on the number of lost parking spaces and options to prevent losing spaces, option to include a roof like at River Valley Coop avoid concerns with ice, plowing maintenance, and drainage.

The School Committee and Solar Subcommittee want detailed proposal design with pros/cons, and costs for the two options - canopy or ground mount system.

Need clarification as to whether or not we need to enter into a letter of intent in order to get a site visit and site analysis and what the letter of intent requires of us. The site visit and soil samples will allow them to give us a much more accurate price estimate. Solect had previously stated the soil sampling/analysis would cost \$10k-\$20k – need to confirm. Also, the school no longer has spare funding to cover these upfront costs. It is still possible to write these costs into the grant and conduct soil samples in design phase of project.

Teri reported that MVP staff indicate that we need to include battery backup to have a competitive grant application. Solect estimated battery backup system would add \$300k-\$500 to the project. Using the Elementary school to be a community center during emergencies needs to be a core component of the grant application. Since the new generator is for the well and is located across the road on an unmaintained driveway it is best to have backup system on the school property.

Discussed the pros/cons of going out to bid or using PowerOptions which is an official state non-profit vendor that already performed their own RFP and selected Solect as their contractor. They have completed many similar solar projects across the state. Some members wonder if we could get a cheaper price by going out to bid.

Discussed there is additional space along the rear driveway to expand the size of the ground mounted option. Need to have Solect evaluate the potential. Is this the space where Highway stores sand? If so, can that be moved elsewhere? Andrea confirmed it can't be expanded towards the school because it will interfere with outside student activities.

Vito confirmed that the School Department does not currently have the staff capacity to write or manage the grant and is relying on the town for that assistance.

Vito's preference at this point until we have further analysis is a ground mounted system with battery backup provided it is the most viable for a grant application. There is some concern given the competition for the MVP grants that a smaller lower cost project would be more viable.

Next Steps: Teri will contact Andreas at Solect and Emma the MVP regional coordinator to get more information on the following questions:

For Solect:

1. More clarification on solar canopy design options and costs –
 - a. Full roof canopy system with batter backup and no parking space loss.
 - b. Ground mounted system preferably expanded to account for future electric demand with battery backup system.
2. What site analysis can be done now to gain more clarity on design options and does this require a letter of intent? What does the letter of intent commit the town to? Get a sample letter?
3. Teri will also call around to some of their projects to get references.

For MVP:

1. Viability of application for the more expensive canopy system vs. lower cost ground mounted system?
2. Would MVP fund just the battery backup to make the school viable as an emergency shelter if the town self-funded the lower cost system now and added battery later?

Options for Next meeting dates depending on when Teri has new information preferably as soon as possible: Meeting would be in-person and zoom hybrid.

Thursday 11/21/2024 at 5:30pm

Monday, 11/25/24 5:30pm

Tuesday, 12/3/24 5:30pm

Thursday, 12/5/24 6pm

Meeting adjourned at 7:15pm 4-0-0